

The Best Advice I Ever Got

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PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR

What was the problem that you were grappling with?

In the late 1990s, I was a student at the Law Center of Georgetown University, doing my master's in securities and financial regulations. It required some knowledge of US laws, of which I was quite ignorant, and a lot of knowledge of US securities law, of which I was even more ignorant. Given the clinical nature of the course, we not only had academic professors but also several professors who were leading practitioners of securities law, including the late Arthur Mathews, one of America's greatest securities litigators then. I knew I had to try to work for the legendary lawyer, but did not know how to ask him.

Who did you approach for advice?

I was cheeky enough to rely on an interview he had given to a magazine. Once I had the highest grade, I requested for an appointment and luckily got to see him in his office.

What was the advice you received?

"If you don't ask, you don't get"—this was his motto as a lawyer. I quoted him and told him how much I would value working for him, and that I had to ask, [I] really had to ask. He laughed.

How effective was it in resolving the problem?

I had the job in less than 30 seconds. That's how I literally got my first paid job (not counting my gigs as weekend travel guide to Corbett National Park). Since then, I have often used the learning 'if you don't ask, you don't get', both inside courtrooms and at various forums. **BT**

—ASHISH RUKHAIYAR

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